What Universities (Say They) Teach

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Abstract

This report studies what universities say they teach by reading their public course catalogs. I count how often course titles and descriptions use two groups of words: one linked to progressive themes such as race, gender, identity, diversity, equity, and social justice, and another linked to the Western canon and Western intellectual tradition. The central pattern is a steady rise in the progressive signal alongside a flat-to-declining Western-canon signal: at Stanford the share of courses carrying the progressive signal nearly triples between 2001–2002 and 2025–2026, from 5.2% to 14.3%, while the Western-canon signal stays near 4%, and across the broader sample of sixteen universities the course-weighted progressive signal roughly doubles (from about 6% to 12%) while the Western-canon signal falls (from about 6% to under 5%). The signals differ sharply across fields. At Stanford the Social Sciences are the most progressive area (24.8% of courses in 2025–2026), ahead of the Humanities (16.8%), yet the progressive signal grows even within STEM (5.7%). Stanford stands out for relatively high progressive content overall and in STEM in particular: its 14.3% overall and 5.7% STEM shares exceed both Harvard (9.5% and 4.8%) and Berkeley (10.0% and 4.1%). At Stanford the rise in progressive content outpaces student enrollment—the 14.3% course share falls to 11.0% when weighted by enrollment—so the catalog overstates proportional student exposure; among the professional schools, Law (23.9%) and Education (19.0%) are the most progressive, while Medicine, though lower, has grown markedly to 11.6%. These measures are simple keyword counts, not judgments about course quality or what happens in classrooms.

1 Introduction

This report documents a simple set of facts about the language used in university course catalogs. My objective is to show how the stated curriculum of major American universities has changed over time and how it differs across institutions. Using publicly available catalogs, I measure the prevalence of two broad families of terms in course titles and descriptions: terms associated with progressive, diversity, equity, inclusion, identity, and social-justice themes, and terms associated with the Western canon or Western intellectual tradition.

Recent debates about higher education often turn on claims that universities have become more politicized, and that course content has become more ideologically shaped. Those claims are difficult to evaluate because much of the available evidence is anecdotal, drawn from public controversies, survey responses, or administrative statements rather than from systematic measures

*The data and code used in this report are available upon request; readers who would like to inspect or replicate the analysis should email me at imvial@stanford.edu.

of curricular content. Course catalogs provide one imperfect but broad source of evidence. They do not reveal what happens in the classroom or what instructors believe, but they do show how universities officially describe what students may study. The aim here is therefore to quantify how often politically and ideologically salient themes appear in that public-facing curriculum, how those signals have changed over time, and where they are concentrated.

The report is intentionally descriptive. It does not judge the quality of individual courses, the motives of instructors, or the intellectual seriousness of any field of study. It asks a narrower question: how often do certain themes appear in the official language by which universities describe their courses? Course catalogs are not the curriculum itself, but they are a public record of how universities present that curriculum to students, parents, faculty, administrators, donors, and taxpayers. That record is worth measuring.

The method is deliberately simple. For each course, I combine the title and description and search them for pre-specified keyword lists using transparent matching rules. A course may match the progressive list, the Western-canon list, both, or neither. The resulting measures are rough signals, not definitive classifications, and they will inevitably produce false positives and false negatives. Some courses use a keyword in a way that does not reflect the broader theme; others engage deeply with a theme without using any of the selected words. I choose this approach because it is easy to explain, easy to replicate, and easy to criticize constructively. If the method is wrong in important ways, the errors should be visible enough for others to improve it.

I also want to be explicit about my own priors. I am concerned that activism has changed higher education in ways that are intellectually and institutionally damaging, and I do not think that concern should be hidden from the reader. At the same time, this report does not ask the reader to share that view. Its purpose is to document patterns in the data, not to declare in advance how much progressive or canonical content is appropriate. Readers may look at the same measurements and reach different normative conclusions.

Nor is this report an argument for micromanaging university catalogs from above. I do not believe curricula can be improved by top-down control of individual course descriptions; such efforts are often strategically unwise and counterproductive. The deeper issues in higher education concern institutions, incentives, and people. Still, transparent measurement can be useful. Parents may consult it when evaluating where students might apply, administrators and trustees may use it to understand their own institutions, and researchers, think tanks, and public agencies may refine it and track it over time.

For that reason, the report names universities directly. The point is not to shame particular institutions, but to make comparisons clear and verifiable. An anonymized analysis would be less useful to the very audiences for whom catalog transparency matters. I focus especially on Stanford because it is my own institution and the one I know and care about most, but the broader goal is comparative: to place Stanford in the context of other major universities and to make the evidence portable enough that additional institutions can be added.

The main findings can be previewed briefly. First, the progressive signal grows substantially over time while the Western-canon signal is flat or declining (Figure 1). Second, progressive language is most concentrated in the Social Sciences—ahead of the Humanities—but it rises even within STEM, the least progressive area (Figure 6). Third, Stanford exhibits relatively high progressive content overall, and unusually high progressive content in STEM, compared with peers such as Harvard and Berkeley. Fourth, at Stanford the growth in progressive course content outpaces growth in student enrollment, so the catalog overstates proportional student exposure; within the professional schools the progressive signal is highest in Law and Education, while Medicine has risen markedly from a low base (Figure 3).

The rest of the report proceeds as follows. The next section describes the data sources, the keyword lists, and the classification procedure. Subsequent sections present time-series evidence, patterns by academic area, cross-sectional comparisons across universities, and robustness checks. Throughout, the emphasis is on documentation rather than evaluation: what is being measured, how it is being measured, what the patterns look like, and where the limitations are.

2 Methodology

2.1 Stanford course-catalog data

I begin with Stanford because it is the institution for which I have assembled the most complete data and because it is the institution I know best. The Stanford analysis uses publicly available course-catalog records. The primary Stanford dataset contains 278,067 course entries drawn from twenty-four academic years: 2001–2002 through 2008–2009 and 2010–2011 through 2025–2026.

Because the keyword analysis relies on course descriptions, I exclude years in which fewer than 50% of courses have nontrivial descriptions. This is why 2000–2001 and 2009–2010 are not included in the core Stanford catalog-signal sample. The analysis window therefore begins in 2001–2002.

Each record contains the academic year, department code, course number, title, full description, and quarter availability flags. The title and description are the fields used for keyword matching. Department codes and academic-group fields are used to assign courses to broad academic areas, such as Humanities, Social Sciences, STEM, Medical Sciences, Professional schools, and Other. Course numbers are used to make a rough undergraduate-versus-graduate distinction, with courses numbered below 200 treated as undergraduate and courses numbered 200 or above treated as graduate. These classifications are mechanical and are used only to summarize patterns; they do not affect whether a course matches either keyword list.

One important feature of the Stanford catalog is cross-listing. A single course can appear under multiple department codes: for example, an interdisciplinary seminar may be listed simultaneously in History, Political Science, and Law. In the raw catalog data, each of those appearances is a separate row, usually with the same or nearly the same title and description but with a different department code. These rows are meaningful as catalog listings, but they are not distinct courses.

For the main analysis, the unit of observation is the course-year rather than the department listing. This matters because cross-listed courses are not randomly distributed across the catalog. Interdisciplinary courses, and especially courses in areas such as race, gender, law, policy, area studies, and environmental studies, are often cross-listed across several departments. If every listing were counted separately, such courses would receive more weight simply because they appear in several places in the catalog. A single course matching the progressive or canon keyword list could then be counted two, three, or more times. That would inflate both the number of courses and the number of keyword matches. In 2025–2026, for example, the progressive share among offered catalog rows with observed enrollment is 16.8% if cross-listings and duplicate rows are left in place, compared with 14.3% after deduplicating to the course-year level.

I therefore deduplicate cross-listed courses before computing the main counts. I identify likely duplicates by grouping records with the same academic year, normalized title, and course description. Title normalization strips trailing parenthetical cross-list references that Stanford uses to indicate alternate listings. Within each group, I retain one representative row and record the associated departments. This produces a course-level measure: each distinct course counts once in a given academic year, even if it is advertised through multiple departments.

Table 9 reports the cross-listing adjustment after restricting the catalog to courses with at least one scheduled section in that academic year. Under this restriction, the Stanford data contain

190,405 raw catalog rows and 143,574 unique course-year observations after deduplication, meaning that 46,831 raw rows, or 24.6%, are removed as duplicate cross-listed appearances.

Table 9 also clarifies the growth in Stanford's offered-course inventory. After restricting to courses with at least one scheduled section and removing cross-listed duplicates, the number of unique offered courses rises from 4,432 in 2001–2002 to 6,722 in 2025–2026. This is a substantial increase, but it is not a continuous recent acceleration. Most of the growth occurs between the early 2000s and the mid-2010s: the series reaches 6,860 unique offered courses in 2016–2017 and then remains roughly flat, ending slightly below that level in 2025–2026.

Table 1 reports the distribution of courses by academic area, both as a share of course counts and as a share of enrollment. The sample is restricted to deduplicated offered courses with nonmissing public enrollment counts, so the number of courses is smaller than in Table 9. The course-share column treats each course equally; the enrollment-share column weights each course by its number of enrolled students.

The area groupings are based on department codes, with Medical Sciences separated using Stanford's Medicine academic-group field. STEM includes the core natural-science, engineering, mathematics, statistics, and computing departments outside the medical-school grouping, such as Computer Science, Electrical Engineering, Mechanical Engineering, Civil and Environmental Engineering, Chemistry, Physics, Biology, Mathematics, Statistics, Earth systems, and related technical fields. Medical Sciences includes courses listed in the Medicine academic group, including biomedical, clinical, and health-science departments. Professional includes the main non-medical professional-school and professional-program departments, including Law, Business, Education, and Public Policy.

Table 1: Stanford course and enrollment distribution by academic area, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

Area	Courses	Course share (%)	Enrollment	Enrollment share (%)
Humanities	22,548	17.1	328,272	8.4
Social Sciences	15,365	11.6	387,942	10.0
STEM	32,333	24.5	1,587,472	40.8
Medical Sciences	12,401	9.4	280,657	7.2
Professional	14,492	11.0	577,042	14.8
Other	34,758	26.4	733,610	18.8
Total	131,897	100.0	3,894,995	100.0

The main difference between the two columns is that STEM accounts for a much larger share of enrollment than of course listings, while Humanities and Medical Sciences account for smaller shares of enrollment than of course listings. This is consistent with STEM courses being larger on average and many Humanities and medical-science courses being smaller seminars or specialized offerings.

2.2 Keyword signals

The report uses two keyword-based signals. The first is a progressive signal, intended to capture course-title and course-description language associated with diversity, equity, inclusion, identity, social justice, race, gender, sexuality, colonialism, oppression, Indigenous studies, bias, and related themes. The second is a Western-canon signal, intended to capture language associated with classical antiquity, the Western intellectual tradition, canonical authors, canonical texts, and adjacent historical periods such as the Renaissance and Enlightenment.

For each deduplicated course-year observation, I combine the course title and course description into a single text field. I then search that field for the keyword lists in Tables 2 and 3. Matching is case-insensitive and uses word-boundary regular expressions, so that a term such as "race" is matched as a word but not as part of an unrelated word such as "interface." Multi-word phrases are matched as phrases. A course is assigned to a signal if its title or description contains at least one keyword from that list.

The two signals are not mutually exclusive. A course can match the progressive list, the Western-canon list, both lists, or neither list. The main measure is binary: a course either has the signal or it does not. I do not give extra weight to a course because it contains several keywords from the same list. This keeps the measure simple and makes the results easier to replicate.

Several obvious limitations follow from this design. Some keywords have common meanings outside the intended signal. The clearest examples are *equity*, which often appears in finance courses in phrases such as private equity or equity markets; *diverse* and *diversity*, which often refer to biological, ecological, methodological, or material variety; and *race*, which can occasionally refer to athletic or motorsport competition rather than race as a social category. These cases are not subtle, and they mechanically inflate the progressive signal to some extent. I do not attempt to correct them in the baseline measure, because the first objective is to keep the rule transparent and reproducible. I return to these false-positive concerns in the robustness section.

A related concern is that the keyword lists may be less informative in STEM fields than in the humanities, social sciences, and professional schools. The Western-canon list is also naturally less relevant to most technical fields.

The Western-tradition signal is especially difficult to define with a short keyword list. The Western intellectual tradition is broad and internally diverse, spanning literature, philosophy, religion, history, political thought, art, music, law, and science across many centuries. The keyword list is therefore not meant to be comprehensive. It will miss many courses that engage seriously with Western texts or ideas without mentioning one of the selected authors, periods, or labels. These are false negatives. There may also be false positives in a different sense: a course may mention a canonical author or text primarily in order to critique, deconstruct, or reinterpret it through a contemporary framework such as intersectionality. I do not attempt to distinguish those cases in the baseline measure. Even with these limitations, changes over time and cross-sectional differences across universities may still be informative, provided the measure is interpreted as a rough keyword signal rather than a complete inventory of Western-tradition teaching.

Table 2: Progressive-signal keyword list by thematic category.

Category	**Keywords**
Race & Racism	race, racial, racism, racist, anti-racist, antiracist, critical race, systemic racism, racial justice, structural racism, institutional racism, white supremacy, white privilege
Equity & Social Justice	equity, equitable, social justice, restorative justice
Diversity & Inclusion	diversity, diverse, inclusion, inclusive, inclusivity, belonging, underrepresented
Gender & Sexuality	gender, gendered, queer, LGBTQ, transgender, non-binary, nonbinary, feminist, feminism, sexuality studies
Colonialism & Postcolonialism	decolonial, decolonize, decolonization, postcolonial, settler colonialism, neocolonial
Intersectionality & Oppression	identity politics, intersectional, intersectionality, privilege, privileged, oppression, oppressed, marginalized, marginalization
Indigenous Studies	indigenous, native peoples
Bias & Cultural Competence	implicit bias, microaggression, cultural competence, allyship

Table 3: Western-canon keyword list by thematic category.

Category	**Keywords**
Tradition Framing	western civilization, western tradition, western thought, great books, liberal arts tradition
Classical Antiquity	ancient Greece, ancient Rome, Greek philosophy, Roman law, classical antiquity, Greco-Roman
Historical Periods	Renaissance, Enlightenment, medieval philosophy, Reformation
Canonical Authors	Shakespeare, Plato, Aristotle, Homer, Dante, Virgil, Milton, Cicero, Socrates, Augustine, Aquinas, Machiavelli, Hobbes, Descartes, Kant, Hegel, Locke, Tocqueville, Montesquieu
Canonical Texts	Bible, biblical, Iliad, Odyssey, Aeneid, Divine Comedy, Canterbury Tales, Leviathan, Federalist
Classical Markers	classics, classical

3 Stanford Time-Series Evidence

Figure 1 plots the evolution of the two signals at Stanford from 2001–2002 through 2025–2026, both with and without enrollment weights. The unweighted series counts each deduplicated offered course equally. The enrollment-weighted series weights each course by the number of enrolled students. To make the comparison consistent, both series are computed on the subset of deduplicated offered courses with nonmissing public enrollment counts.

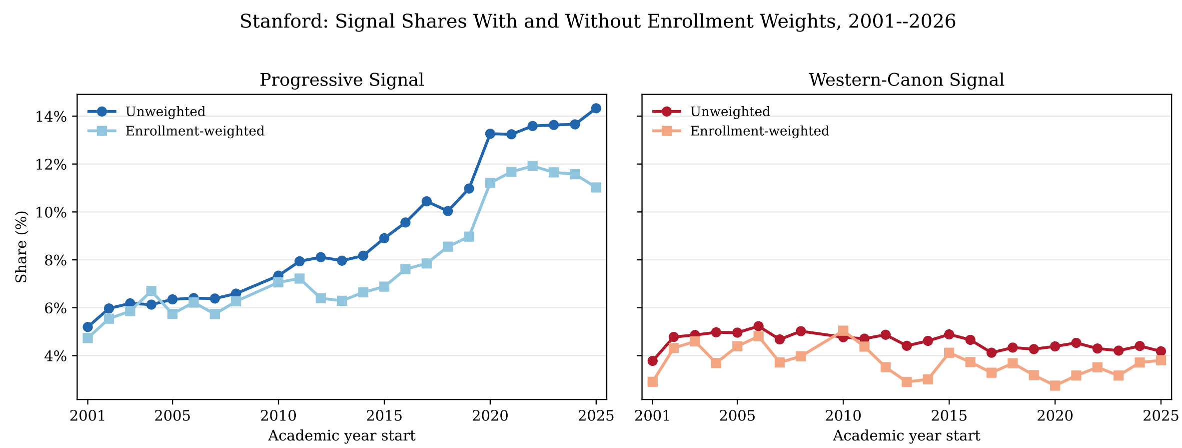

Figure 1: Stanford: progressive and Western-canon signal shares with and without enrollment weights, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

The progressive signal rises substantially under both counting rules. On an unweighted basis, it increases from 5.2% of courses in 2001–2002 to 14.3% in 2025–2026. On an enrollment-weighted basis, it rises from 4.7% of student-seats to 11.0%. The enrollment-weighted line is generally below the unweighted line, especially in later years, which means that progressive-signal courses tend to enroll fewer students than the average course in the enrollment-observed sample. The difference does not eliminate the trend: the rise is visible whether courses are counted equally or weighted by enrollment.

The gap between the course share and the enrollment share is useful because it separates catalog availability from student exposure. In 2025–2026, progressive-signal courses make up 14.3%

of offered courses but 11.0% of enrollment. This suggests that progressive-signal courses are more prominent in Stanford's catalog than in students' actual course-taking. One possible interpretation is that the supply of such courses has grown faster than student demand for them. That interpretation should be treated cautiously, however. Enrollment differences may also reflect course caps, field composition, graduate seminars, major requirements, and the smaller size of many humanities, social-science, and professional-school courses. The evidence therefore does not establish administrative intent. It does show that the catalog somewhat overstates proportional student exposure to progressive-signal courses, even though the enrollment-weighted exposure also rises substantially over time.

The Western-canon signal is much flatter. The unweighted series begins at 3.8% in 2001–2002 and ends at 4.2% in 2025–2026, with fluctuations in between. The enrollment-weighted series likewise fluctuates but does not show the same upward movement as the progressive signal. Taken together, the figure suggests that the main Stanford time-series pattern is growth in the progressive signal rather than a parallel increase in both keyword families.

3.1 Progressive categories

Figure 2 zooms in on the progressive signal by plotting the share of offered courses that match the four largest progressive keyword categories. The figure uses the same deduplicated, enrollment-observed Stanford sample as Figure 1, but reports unweighted course shares. The categories are not mutually exclusive: a course that mentions, for example, both race and gender contributes to both category lines.

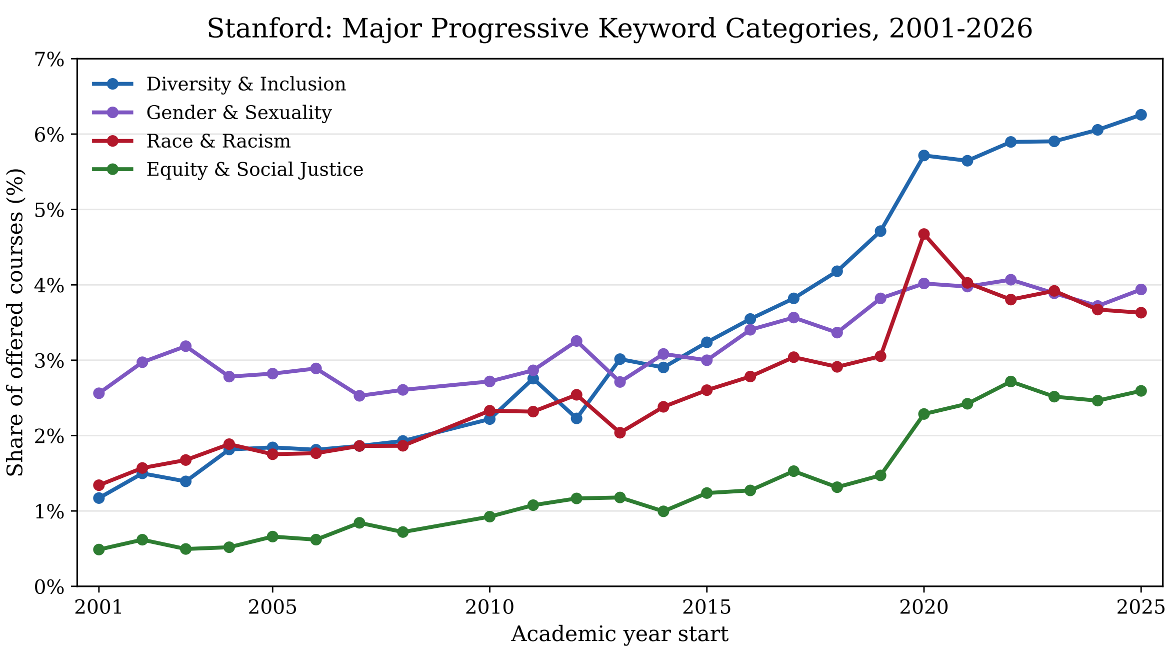

Figure 2: Stanford major progressive keyword-category shares, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

The largest increase is in Diversity and Inclusion terms, which rise from 1.2% of courses in 2001–2002 to 6.3% in 2025–2026. Race and Racism terms rise from 1.3% to 3.6%, with a visible spike around 2020–2021 before settling at a higher level than in the early years. Equity and Social Justice terms also grow substantially, from 0.5% to 2.6%. Gender and Sexuality terms start from a higher baseline than most other categories and increase more modestly, from 2.6% to 3.9%.

Thus, the aggregate rise in the progressive signal is not driven by a single keyword family, but the largest contribution comes from the broad Diversity and Inclusion category. Because that category includes words such as *diverse*, *diversity*, and *inclusion*, it is also one of the places where false positives are most likely to matter.

3.2 Breakdown by area

Table 4 reports the same two signals by academic area, again with and without enrollment weights, for the latest Stanford catalog year. The sample is the 2025–2026 enrollment-observed sample used for the final point in Figure 1.

Table 4: Stanford progressive and Western-canon signal prevalence by academic area, unweighted and enrollment-weighted, 2025–2026.

	Progressive (%)		Canon (%)			
Area	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Courses	Enrollment
Overall	14.3	11.0	4.2	3.8	6,170	166,742
Humanities	16.8	15.7	13.7	14.5	1,092	13,345
Social Sciences	24.8	18.7	2.5	1.6	790	13,268
STEM	5.7	3.8	2.0	2.2	1,444	74,659
Medical Sciences	11.7	7.1	0.6	0.3	819	17,719
Professional	20.0	20.5	0.7	0.5	715	22,041
Other	14.0	20.2	3.7	9.3	1,310	25,710

Because Table 4 is restricted to 2025–2026, its Overall row corresponds to the endpoint of Figure 1: 14.3% of courses and 11.0% of enrollment carry the progressive signal. The table should therefore be read as a latest-year cross-section rather than a historical average.

The progressive signal is highest in Social Sciences and Professional schools. In Social Sciences, 24.8% of courses and 18.7% of enrollment carry the progressive signal. In Professional schools, the corresponding figures are 20.0% and 20.5%. Humanities is also high, at 16.8% of courses and 15.7% of enrollment. Medical Sciences is lower than those areas but above STEM, at 11.7% of courses and 7.1% of enrollment. STEM is lower, at 5.7% of courses and 3.8% of enrollment.

The Western-canon signal is concentrated in Humanities. Humanities has a canon share of 13.7% by course count and 14.5% by enrollment, far above Social Sciences, STEM, Medical Sciences, and Professional schools. The STEM canon signal mostly reflects false-positive uses of “classical” or “classics” in technical contexts, such as classical mechanics or classical thermodynamics, as expected. The residual Other category is mixed because it contains interdisciplinary, language, writing, overseas, and other programs; it has a higher enrollment-weighted canon share than course-count canon share.

Enrollment weighting changes the area patterns in informative ways. For the progressive signal, weighting lowers the Overall share and especially the Social Sciences, Medical Sciences, and STEM shares, suggesting that progressive-signal courses in those areas are smaller than the average course in the same area. In Professional schools, the progressive course share and enrollment share are nearly identical. For the Western-canon signal, enrollment weighting raises the Humanities share and the residual Other share, which means that canon-signal courses in those areas enroll more students than the average course in the same area.

3.3 Professional schools

The Professional category in Table 4 is not a black box. In the Stanford area taxonomy used there, Professional refers to non-medical professional-school and professional-program course codes: Law, Graduate School of Business-related fields, Education, and Public Policy. Medicine is reported separately in the Medical Sciences row of the area table. For the professional-school comparison in this subsection, however, I also include the Stanford School of Medicine, operationalized as courses in Stanford's Medicine academic group. This makes it possible to compare the main professional schools directly while preserving the broader area distinction used above.

Figure 3 plots the course-count progressive signal within these professional programs and Medicine. The figure uses the same deduplicated, offered, enrollment-observed Stanford sample as Table 4. Public Policy is a small category, so its year-to-year movements should be interpreted cautiously.

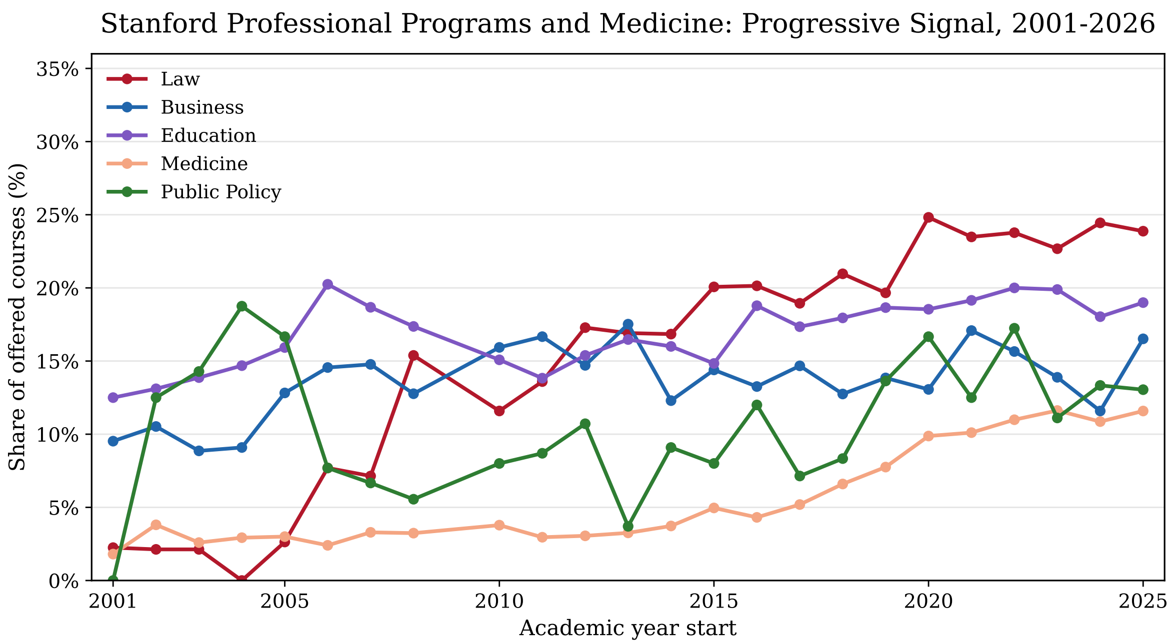

Figure 3: Stanford professional programs and Medicine: progressive-signal course shares, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

Law shows the clearest long-run increase. It begins from a low baseline in the early 2000s and reaches 23.9% of courses in 2025–2026. Education is steadier and ends at 19.0%. Business is less monotonic by course count, ending at 16.5%, but Table 5 shows that its enrollment-weighted progressive share is much higher, at 24.3%.[1] This means that, within Business, courses carrying the progressive signal enroll more students than the average business course. The opposite pattern appears in Law: 23.9% of courses but 14.6% of enrollment carry the progressive signal, indicating that progressive-signal Law courses are smaller than the average Law course. Medicine is lower than Law, Business, and Education in 2025–2026, at 11.6% of courses and 7.1% of enrollment, but

[1]The Business estimate is especially affected by finance uses of *equity*. Applying the false-positive audit rules from Appendix B to the 2025–2026 Business subset flags 14 of 37 progressive-signal Business courses, with 1,124 of 3,000 progressive-signal enrollments, as obvious false positives, all from finance or business-equity usages such as private equity or equity markets. Removing those cases lowers the Business progressive share to 10.3% by course count and 15.2% by enrollment.

it also rises clearly over the period.

Table 5: Stanford professional-school and Medicine signal prevalence by school or program, unweighted and enrollment-weighted, 2025–2026.

	Progressive (%)		Canon (%)			
School/program	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Courses	Enrollment
Law	23.9	14.6	1.4	0.8	289	6,440
Business	16.5	24.3	0.4	0.4	224	12,321
Education	19.0	18.8	0.0	0.0	179	2,773
Medicine	11.6	7.1	0.5	0.3	820	17,690
Public Policy	13.0	11.7	0.0	0.0	23	494
Total incl. Medicine	15.5	14.5	0.6	0.4	1,535	39,718

The Western-canon signal is essentially absent from these professional programs and Medicine. In 2025–2026 it is 0.6% by course count and 0.4% by enrollment for the combined category. Thus, the distinctive fact about the professional schools is not a tradeoff between progressive and canon language inside the same curricular space. It is that professional programs, especially Law and Business, contain substantial progressive-language signals while containing very little Western-canon language; Medicine is lower on the progressive signal, but also has almost no canon signal.

4 Cross-Sectional Evidence

4.1 Data from other universities

The Stanford evidence is useful because the data are unusually rich, especially once enrollment counts are linked to the catalog. Cross-sectional comparisons require a broader but less uniform dataset. I therefore combine Stanford with fifteen additional universities for which I have assembled public course-catalog data. These institutions include private research universities, large public flagships, and a technically oriented institution. The sample is not meant to represent all of American higher education: it omits community colleges, regional public universities, and most liberal-arts colleges. It is instead a comparison set of major research universities whose catalogs can be collected and parsed at scale.

The cross-university data are heterogeneous. Some universities publish structured catalog or course-search data that can be converted directly into course-year records. Others require scraping archived web catalogs or extracting course descriptions from PDF bulletins. For each university, the parser maps local fields into a common structure: academic year, department or subject code, course number, title, description, and broad academic area. In a few cases, the available source is a constituent college catalog rather than a full university-wide catalog. This is especially relevant for U. Chicago and Columbia: the U. Chicago files are The College catalogs, and the Columbia files are Columbia College bulletins. These rows should therefore be read as evidence about those college catalogs, not as complete coverage of all professional and graduate offerings at the university. The keyword lists are held fixed across universities. Because comparable enrollment data are generally not available outside Stanford, Stanford enters this section using unweighted course counts rather than student-seat weights.

Table 10 reports the coverage of the comparison sample. Altogether, these catalogs contain more than one million course-year observations, but the length and density of coverage vary substantially by institution. Some datasets span several decades, as at Harvard, Berkeley, Northwestern, and

NYU. Others cover shorter windows, either because the relevant catalog archives are shorter or because the current parser has only been implemented for recent years. This matters for interpretation: the cross-sectional evidence is strongest as a comparison of catalog language within the observed windows, not as a balanced panel in which every university is observed over the same years.

4.2 Composition of university catalogs

Before comparing keyword signals across universities, it is important to examine catalog composition. Universities differ mechanically in the mix of courses they offer. A technical institute, a large public flagship, and a humanities-heavy private university will have different baseline exposure to the keyword lists even if departments within each area behave similarly. This matters because, in the Stanford evidence, the Western-canon signal is concentrated in Humanities, while the progressive signal is relatively more common in Social Sciences and Professional schools and lower in STEM.

Table 11 shows that catalog composition differs sharply across the comparison set. MIT is the clearest STEM-heavy case, with more than half of its catalog observations classified as STEM. Texas A&M, UIUC, Berkeley, Cornell, Northwestern, and Stanford also have large STEM shares. By contrast, Princeton, NYU, and Yale are much more humanities-heavy in these catalog data. U. Chicago and Columbia also appear humanities-heavy, but that partly reflects the fact that the available source for each is a college catalog rather than a full university-wide catalog. For this five-area cross-university table, Stanford Medical Sciences are folded into Professional so that Stanford fits the same area taxonomy used for the other universities. Some universities also have large residual Other categories, reflecting interdisciplinary programs, language programs, writing programs, overseas studies, or local catalog structures that do not map cleanly into the broad area codes.

These compositional differences are not a nuisance to be ignored. They are part of what students encounter when they browse a university catalog. At the same time, they complicate cross-university comparisons of ideological or canonical signals. A university can have a higher overall canon share partly because it has more Humanities courses, or a lower progressive share partly because it has a larger STEM catalog. For that reason, the cross-sectional results below should be read together with the area composition table and, where possible, compared within academic areas as well as overall.

4.3 Evolution of the two signals

Figure 4 plots the evolution of the progressive and Western-canon signals in the comparison sample, including Stanford on the same unweighted course-count basis as the other universities. The colored lines show individual universities. The panel is unbalanced: universities enter and exit the sample depending on catalog availability and parser coverage. The figure should therefore be read as a descriptive view of institution-specific variation in the observed catalog panel, rather than as a balanced fixed set of institutions followed over time.

Figure 5 reports the course-weighted average series across universities observed in each year. This simpler view puts the two aggregate signals on the same axis and makes the divergence between them easier to see.

The most notable fact in Figure 5 is the opening gap between the two signals. In 1999, the progressive and Western-canon shares are nearly identical, at 6.4% each. By 2025, the progressive share is 11.5%, while the Western-canon share is 4.6%. Thus, in the observed catalog panel, progressive-

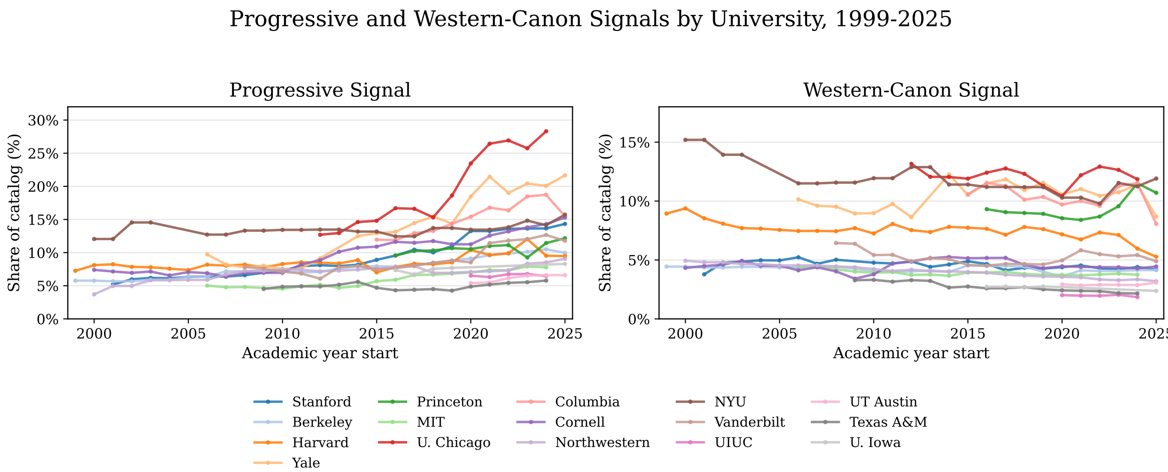

Figure 4: Progressive and Western-canon signal shares by university, 1999–2025.

signal course descriptions become more common while Western-canon-signal descriptions become less common.

The individual university lines show substantial dispersion around that average. U. Chicago, Columbia, Yale, and NYU tend to have relatively high Western-canon shares, consistent with their more humanities-heavy catalogs and, in the case of U. Chicago and Columbia, the fact that the available source files are college catalogs. STEM-heavy institutions such as MIT, UIUC, Texas A&M, and UT Austin tend to sit lower on the Western-canon signal. Progressive shares also vary meaningfully across universities, with the highest observed levels appearing in humanities- or college-catalog settings and lower levels in several STEM-heavy public universities.

The time-series pattern in the weighted average is gradual rather than a single-year break. The progressive share rises from the mid-single digits in the early 2000s to roughly 9–12% in the 2010s and early 2020s, with a local high of 11.7% in 2024. The Western-canon signal moves in the opposite direction: it is around 5–6% for much of the 2000s and early 2010s, then falls closer to 4–5% in the later years. By the end of the sample, the weighted-average progressive share is more than twice the Western-canon share.

These patterns are consistent with the Stanford time-series evidence, but the comparison is not exact. The cross-university figures use course counts rather than enrollment weights, and the weighted average pools a changing set of institutions with different catalog structures. The individual lines make this caveat visible: part of the movement in the average reflects genuine within-university change, and part reflects which universities are observed in a given year. Even with those caveats, the direction of change is clear in the weighted panel: the relative prevalence of progressive-language signals rises, while the relative prevalence of Western-canon-language signals declines.

Figure 6 decomposes the pooled progressive signal of Figure 5 into the five broad academic areas used in Table 11. Each line is a course-weighted average over all universities observed in a given year, so the composition of the panel changes as universities enter and exit. Because Law, Education, and Medicine cannot be separated consistently across these catalogs, they are contained within the Professional area; most of the comparison catalogs are undergraduate or college catalogs with limited professional-school coverage.

The area ordering is stable and matches the Stanford cross-section. Social Sciences carries the highest progressive signal throughout, rising from about 10.6% of courses in 2001 to 18.6% by 2024.

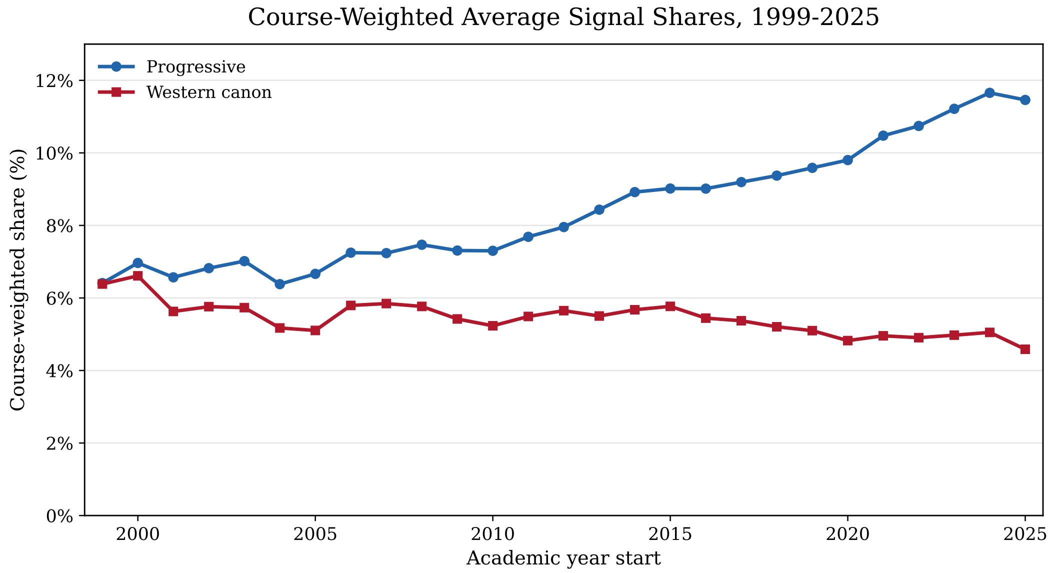

Figure 5: Course-weighted average progressive and Western-canon signal shares across observed catalogs, 1999–2025.

Humanities is second and rises the most in proportional terms, roughly doubling from about 7.9% to 15.9% over the same window. Professional and the residual Other category occupy the middle of the range, ending near 12% and 10% respectively, while STEM remains far below all of them, rising only from about 2.2% to 4.3%. Every non-STEM area moves upward over the period, so the aggregate increase documented in Figure 5 is broad-based rather than driven by a single area, but it is led by Social Sciences and Humanities. As in the previous figures, the dip in the final year reflects the smaller set of universities with a 2025 catalog and should not be read as a reversal.

For reference, Table 6 reports each university's latest available signal shares when the comparison panel includes a 2024 or 2025 catalog observation. The table also reports the ratio of the progressive share to the Western-canon share and sorts universities from the highest ratio to the lowest. Because the table reports shares rather than course counts, it should be read as a near-current cross-sectional snapshot rather than a measure of university size.

Tables 7 and 8 repeat the same near-current cross-section after splitting the catalog by STEM status. The first table excludes courses classified as STEM; the second keeps only STEM courses. The university-year observation is otherwise the same as in Table 6.

Splitting by STEM status sharpens two facts. First, the progressive signal is concentrated outside STEM at every university: STEM progressive shares are uniformly low, mostly between 1% and 6%, while non-STEM shares are several times higher. Second, Stanford sits high on both margins relative to comparable research universities. Its overall progressive share (14.3%) exceeds Harvard's (9.5%) and Berkeley's (10.0%), and its STEM progressive share (5.7%) is higher than both (4.8% and 4.1%) and is among the highest in the whole sample, behind only U. Chicago and Cornell. The institutions above Stanford on the overall measure are mostly humanities-heavy or college-catalog settings, so Stanford's elevated signal is notable given that it is a comparatively STEM-heavy university.

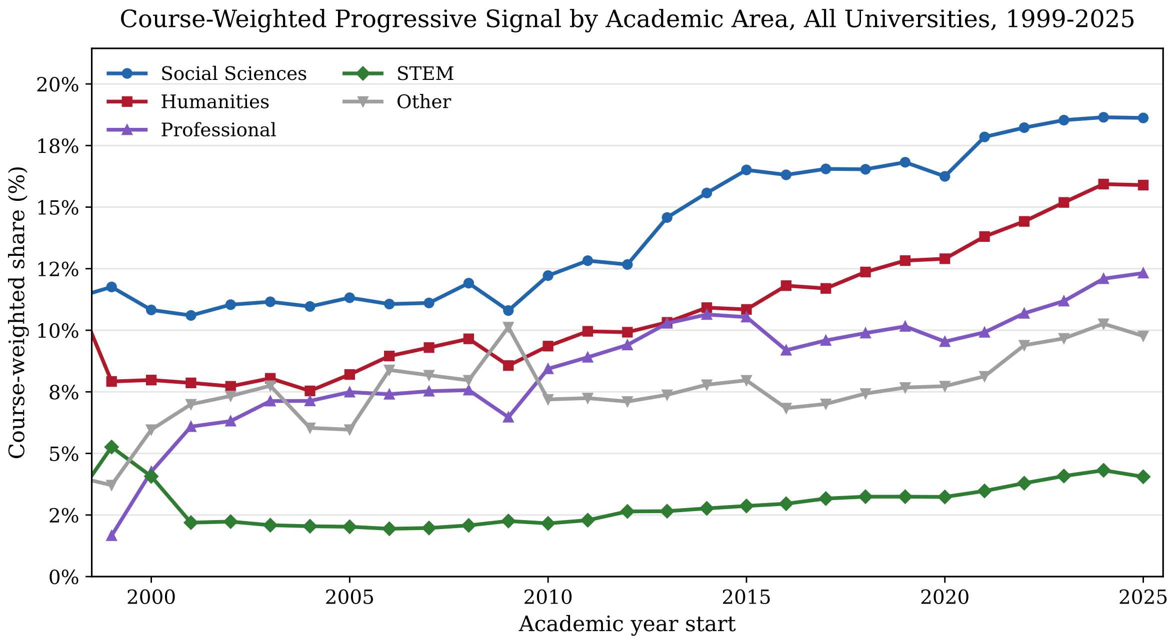

Figure 6: Course-weighted average progressive-signal share by broad academic area across observed catalogs, 1999–2025.

5 Conclusion

This report documents four main findings. First, the progressive signal rises substantially over the observed period while the Western-canon signal is flat to declining: at Stanford the progressive course share nearly triples, from 5.2% in 2001–2002 to 14.3% in 2025–2026, while the Western-canon share barely moves, and across the broader university panel the progressive signal rises while the Western-canon signal falls (Figure 1). Second, the signals are uneven across the curriculum. The Social Sciences carry the strongest progressive signal—ahead of the Humanities—while the Western-canon signal is concentrated in the Humanities; even STEM, which remains the least progressive area, shows a clear upward trend (Figure 6). Third, Stanford stands out among its peers: its progressive content is relatively high overall (14.3%, versus 9.5% at Harvard and 10.0% at Berkeley) and relatively high within STEM in particular (5.7%, versus 4.8% and 4.1%). Fourth, at Stanford the growth in progressive content outpaces student enrollment, so the catalog overstates proportional student exposure; among the professional schools, Law and Education are the most progressive, while Medicine, though lower, has grown markedly over the period (Figure 3).

The analysis also has important limitations. Course catalogs are public descriptions, not classroom observations. They do not show what instructors actually assign, how a course is taught, or what students learn. Keyword lists are also imperfect. They produce false positives, miss courses that use different language, and may work better in some fields than in others. Catalogs also differ across universities in coverage, description length, source format, and whether the available files describe the whole university or a constituent college. These limitations mean that the measures should be read as rough, comparable signals rather than precise estimates of course content.

The next step is to make this kind of measurement more systematic. A useful goal would be a regularly updated public index of university catalog politicization, in the spirit of FIRE's free-speech rankings: transparent enough to audit, broad enough to compare institutions, and stable

Table 6: Progressive and Western-canon signal shares by university, latest available 2024 or 2025 catalog observation.

University	Year	Progressive %	Canon %	Prog./canon
U. Iowa	2025	8.3	2.4	3.49
UIUC	2024	6.5	1.9	3.49
Cornell	2025	15.3	4.4	3.44
Stanford	2025	14.3	4.2	3.43
Northwestern	2025	9.1	3.2	2.84
Texas A&M	2024	5.8	2.2	2.68
Yale	2025	21.7	8.7	2.49
Vanderbilt	2025	11.8	4.9	2.41
Berkeley	2025	10.0	4.1	2.41
U. Chicago	2024	28.3	11.9	2.39
UT Austin	2025	6.6	3.1	2.14
MIT	2024	7.8	3.7	2.08
Columbia	2025	15.5	8.1	1.92
Harvard	2025	9.5	5.3	1.80
NYU	2025	15.7	11.9	1.32
Princeton	2025	12.2	10.7	1.14

enough to track change over time. Such an index should report not only overall university scores, but also area-level patterns, changes over time, description-length adjustments, and sensitivity to alternative keyword lists.

Further research should also move beyond catalogs. Enrollment data can show how much student exposure differs from the raw course count. Syllabi would be even more informative, because they contain readings, assignments, and weekly topics rather than short catalog descriptions. Combining catalogs, enrollments, and syllabi would make it possible to measure not only what universities claim to teach, but also what students are most likely to encounter. This report is a first pass at that measurement problem, and the hope is that others will improve the data, challenge the classifications, and build more durable tools for tracking curricular change.

A Supplementary Data and Methodology Tables

This appendix collects three reference tables cited in the main text: the Stanford cross-listing deduplication counts by year (Table 9), the coverage of the cross-university catalog sample (Table 10), and the composition of each catalog by broad academic area (Table 11).

B Obvious False Positives in the Stanford Progressive Signal

This appendix asks a narrow validation question: among Stanford course-years flagged by the progressive keyword list, how many are obvious false positives? I do not try to adjudicate ambiguous cases. A course-year is counted as a false positive only if every progressive keyword match in its title and description falls inside a clearly non-progressive usage. Examples include *equity* in finance courses, as in private equity or equity markets; biological or wireless-communications uses of *diversity*; administrative uses of *belonging*, as in sections belonging to a thesis adviser; technical

Table 7: Progressive and Western-canon signal shares by university, latest available 2024 or 2025 catalog observation, excluding STEM courses.

University	Year	Progressive %	Canon %
Stanford	2025	17.0	4.8
Berkeley	2025	11.6	4.8
Harvard	2025	10.6	5.7
Yale	2025	25.5	9.8
Princeton	2025	15.0	12.9
MIT	2024	13.0	4.7
U. Chicago	2024	30.5	12.9
Columbia	2025	18.8	9.5
Cornell	2025	18.6	5.1
Northwestern	2025	11.7	3.9
NYU	2025	17.3	13.4
Vanderbilt	2025	14.0	5.8
UIUC	2024	8.2	1.9
UT Austin	2025	7.7	3.5
Texas A&M	2024	7.2	2.4
U. Iowa	2025	9.2	2.3

uses of *inclusion*; non-identity uses of *race*, as in the space race or the human race; grammatical gender; legal privilege; and double-marginalization in microeconomics. If a course contains any additional progressive keyword outside these obvious contexts, I leave it in the progressive-signal category.

The estimate is modest. In the deduplicated Stanford sample with at least one scheduled section and observed enrollment, 758 of 12,586 progressive-signal course-years are obvious false positives, or 6.0%. In 2025–2026, the corresponding estimate is 50 of 884, or 5.7%. Removing these cases would reduce the 2025–2026 unweighted progressive share from 14.3% to 13.5%. This does not eliminate the main Stanford finding, though it does show that a small part of the progressive signal comes from mechanical keyword ambiguity. The largest source is *equity* in business and finance, followed by generic or technical uses of *diverse* and *diversity*.

This should be read as a lower-bound audit of false positives, not as a full validation of the keyword list. There are surely ambiguous cases that I do not remove here. There are also important false negatives. Courses may discuss related themes using words outside the list, such as inequality, discrimination, segregation, immigration, disability, human rights, women, patriarchy, sexism, empire, tribal law, or Native American law. Catalog descriptions may also omit topics that appear in syllabi, readings, assignments, or class discussion. The false-positive audit therefore supports a limited conclusion: the obvious mechanical false positives are real but not large enough to drive the Stanford results by themselves.

C Climate-Related Topics

This appendix reports a separate Stanford time series for climate-related course descriptions. I keep this measure separate from the main progressive and Western-canon signals because climate is not a synonym for either category. Some climate courses are scientific or technical, some are

Table 8: Progressive and Western-canon signal shares by university, latest available 2024 or 2025 catalog observation, STEM courses only.

University	Year	Progressive %	Canon %
Stanford	2025	5.7	2.0
Berkeley	2025	4.1	1.7
Harvard	2025	4.8	3.4
Yale	2025	4.3	3.5
Princeton	2025	3.3	3.9
MIT	2024	2.1	2.7
U. Chicago	2024	10.7	3.4
Columbia	2025	2.6	2.6
Cornell	2025	6.0	2.5
Northwestern	2025	1.9	1.4
NYU	2025	5.4	1.6
Vanderbilt	2025	2.8	1.2
UIUC	2024	2.2	1.7
UT Austin	2025	1.3	1.1
Texas A&M	2024	1.5	1.3
U. Iowa	2025	1.4	2.7

policy-oriented, and some connect climate to justice, inequality, or institutional reform. Treating climate as its own topic is therefore more informative than folding it into the baseline progressive list.

I use two keyword definitions. The narrow climate signal includes phrases such as *climate change*, *global warming*, *greenhouse gas*, *carbon emissions*, *decarbonization*, *net zero*, *climate policy*, *climate science*, *climate adaptation*, *climate mitigation*, and *climate justice*. The broader sensitivity measure includes the narrow list and adds terms such as *sustainability*, *sustainable*, *sustainable development*, *renewable energy*, and *clean energy*. The broader measure is useful because many climate-related courses use sustainability language, but it is also less precise: *sustainable* can describe business models, engineering systems, agriculture, development, or institutional practices without necessarily centering climate change.

Figure 7 plots both definitions on the same deduplicated, enrollment-observed Stanford sample used in the main Stanford time-series analysis. The climate signal grows steadily over the period. The narrow climate share rises from 0.4% of offered courses in 2001–2002 to 2.8% in 2025–2026. The broader climate-or-sustainability share rises from 0.7% to 5.2%. Enrollment-weighted exposure also rises, but remains below the course share in the latest year: in 2025–2026, the narrow climate signal accounts for 1.9% of enrollment and the broader measure accounts for 3.8%. As with the progressive signal, this gap suggests that climate-related offerings are more visible in the catalog than in proportional student-seat exposure, likely because many such courses are specialized seminars or field-specific offerings.

Figure 8 repeats the exercise for Stanford STEM courses only, excluding Medical Sciences. In STEM, the climate-related rise is more pronounced in course-count terms. The narrow climate share rises from 0.7% of STEM courses in 2001–2002 to 3.9% in 2025–2026, while the broader climate-or-sustainability share rises from 0.9% to 8.4%. The enrollment-weighted shares are lower, especially for the narrow climate definition: in 2025–2026, narrow climate courses account for 1.2% of STEM enrollment, while the broader measure accounts for 3.5%. This pattern suggests

Table 9: Impact of crosslisted course deduplication by academic year, restricted to courses with at least one scheduled section.

Year	Raw rows	Unique courses	Duplicates removed	Crosslisted groups	% removed
2001–2002	6,255	4,432	1,823	1,203	29.1%
2002–2003	6,692	4,549	2,143	1,367	32.0%
2003–2004	6,595	4,593	2,002	1,264	30.4%
2004–2005	6,777	4,556	2,221	1,397	32.8%
2005–2006	6,907	4,720	2,187	1,391	31.7%
2006–2007	6,027	4,764	1,263	904	21.0%
2007–2008	6,113	4,929	1,184	822	19.4%
2008–2009	6,363	5,169	1,194	830	18.8%
2010–2011	7,411	5,888	1,523	1,003	20.6%
2011–2012	7,580	5,984	1,596	1,046	21.1%
2012–2013	7,951	6,261	1,690	1,107	21.3%
2013–2014	8,295	6,497	1,798	1,186	21.7%
2014–2015	8,645	6,689	1,956	1,243	22.6%
2015–2016	8,901	6,879	2,022	1,282	22.7%
2016–2017	9,031	6,860	2,171	1,346	24.0%
2017–2018	9,035	6,818	2,217	1,367	24.5%
2018–2019	9,246	6,982	2,264	1,357	24.5%
2019–2020	9,159	6,936	2,223	1,333	24.3%
2020–2021	8,630	6,484	2,146	1,275	24.9%
2021–2022	8,892	6,659	2,233	1,306	25.1%
2022–2023	8,758	6,581	2,177	1,294	24.9%
2023–2024	8,988	6,764	2,224	1,332	24.7%
2024–2025	9,125	6,858	2,267	1,377	24.8%
2025–2026	9,029	6,722	2,307	1,388	25.6%
Total	190,405	143,574	46,831	—	24.6%

that climate-related STEM offerings have become much more common as catalog offerings, but that they remain more concentrated in specialized courses than in the largest STEM enrollment channels.

Figure 9 and Table 14 compare the same climate-topic definitions across universities, restricting each catalog to STEM courses in the latest available 2024 or 2025 observation. Unlike the Stanford time-series figure, this cross-university comparison is unweighted by enrollment because comparable enrollment data are not available for the other universities. The table is sorted by the broader climate-or-sustainability measure.

The cross-section shows substantial dispersion. Princeton and Stanford have the highest broad climate-or-sustainability STEM shares, at 9.4% and 8.4%, followed by NYU, Cornell, and MIT. Harvard, Iowa, UT Austin, Columbia, UIUC, U. Chicago, and Texas A&M are lower, ranging from 0.8% to 2.6% on the broad measure. The narrow climate ranking is not identical: NYU and Princeton are highest, while Stanford remains high but a larger fraction of its broad STEM signal comes from sustainability, renewable-energy, or clean-energy language. These comparisons should be read cautiously because catalog coverage differs across universities, and some entries, such as U. Chicago and Columbia, are college catalogs rather than full university-wide STEM catalogs. Still, the broad pattern is informative: climate-related STEM language is not evenly distributed across institutions.

The main substantive point is that climate-related language becomes much more common in

Table 10: University catalog data used for cross-sectional comparisons.

University	Year starts	Catalog years	Course-years	Latest-year courses
Stanford	2001–2025	24	131,897	6,170
Berkeley	1999–2025	27	191,558	11,840
Harvard	1990–2026	37	120,567	2,694
Yale	2006–2025	19	35,205	1,911
Princeton	2016–2025	10	24,118	1,504
MIT	2006–2024	19	59,089	3,549
U. Chicago	2012–2024	13	21,381	2,741
Columbia	2015–2025	11	24,674	2,468
Cornell	2000–2025	26	191,716	10,675
Northwestern	2000–2025	26	66,216	3,256
NYU	2000–2025	24	49,108	2,409
Vanderbilt	2008–2025	18	58,999	3,597
UIUC	2020–2024	5	29,704	4,537
UT Austin	2020–2025	6	47,739	8,398
Texas A&M	2009–2024	16	50,135	3,805
U. Iowa	2016–2025	5	46,390	9,047

Table 11: Composition of catalog course-year observations by broad academic area.

University	Humanities	Social Sciences	STEM	Professional	Other
Stanford	17.1	11.6	24.5	20.4	26.4
Berkeley	21.5	19.2	26.7	13.0	19.6
Harvard	29.4	15.3	21.1	0.0	34.3
Yale	46.3	24.0	17.2	0.6	11.9
Princeton	54.9	18.9	20.3	4.3	1.6
MIT	21.9	13.3	51.4	7.9	5.5
U. Chicago	51.3	20.1	17.2	0.5	10.9
Columbia	53.1	21.3	18.6	2.2	4.8
Cornell	28.6	20.7	25.8	10.4	14.5
Northwestern	43.0	20.0	26.0	7.3	3.8
NYU	57.7	14.8	11.2	0.0	16.4
Vanderbilt	27.7	20.0	21.7	6.8	23.7
UIUC	25.2	18.3	28.7	21.8	6.1
UT Austin	28.5	20.3	19.1	8.0	24.2
Texas A&M	19.2	12.7	30.7	14.9	22.6
U. Iowa	25.9	11.6	13.4	11.9	37.1

Stanford course descriptions, especially after 2020. That pattern is not surprising given the growth of climate science, energy policy, sustainability research, environmental justice, and climate-focused professional training. It should not automatically be interpreted as evidence of ideological politicization. The same keywords can appear in courses about atmospheric physics, civil engineering, energy systems, environmental economics, law, business strategy, public policy, and social justice. The appendix measure is therefore best read as evidence of the rise of climate as a cross-cutting curricular topic, with the broader sustainability series serving as an upper-bound sensitivity check rather than a precise estimate of climate-change coursework.

Table 12: Obvious false positives in the Stanford progressive signal.

Source	Example trigger	2001–2025	2025–2026
Finance/business equity	private equity; equity research; brand equity	322	22
Legal/economic equitable terms	fair and equitable treatment; equitable remedies	12	1
Biological diversity	biological diversity; genetic diversity; diversity of life	109	8
Technical diversity	wireless-channel diversity; receiver diversity	25	1
Generic diverse	diverse data sources; diverse methods	138	11
Administrative belonging	section belonging to an adviser	59	3
Technical/administrative inclusion	suitable for inclusion; inclusion of variables	52	1
Non-identity race	space race; human race; presidential race	25	3
Grammatical gender	case, gender, tense, and aspect	6	0
Legal privilege	attorney-client privilege; executive privilege	6	0
Economic marginalization	double-marginalization	4	0
Total obvious false positives		758	50
Progressive-signal course-years		12,586	884
False-positive probability		6.0%	5.7%

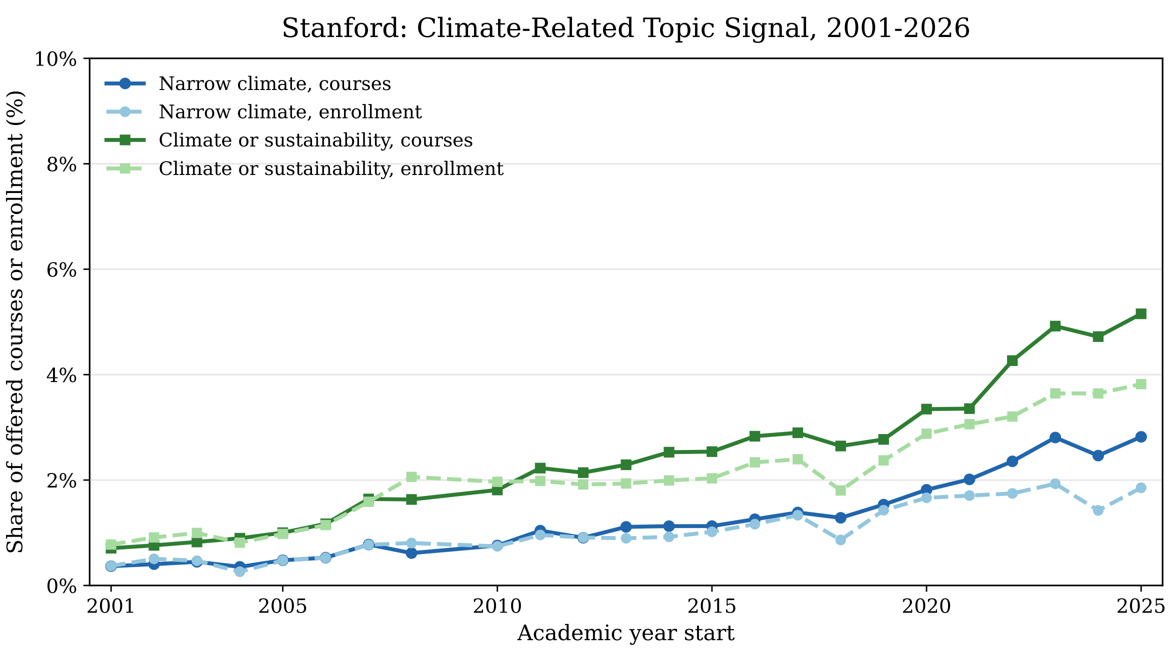

Figure 7: Stanford climate-related topic signal with and without enrollment weights, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

Table 13: Stanford climate-related topic signal, selected academic years.

	Narrow climate (%)		Climate or sustainability (%)		
Year	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Unwtd	Enr-wtd	Courses
2001–2002	0.4	0.4	0.7	0.8	4,100
2005–2006	0.5	0.5	1.0	1.0	4,394
2010–2011	0.8	0.7	1.8	2.0	5,408
2015–2016	1.1	1.0	2.5	2.0	6,301
2020–2021	1.8	1.7	3.3	2.9	5,948
2025–2026	2.8	1.9	5.2	3.8	6,170

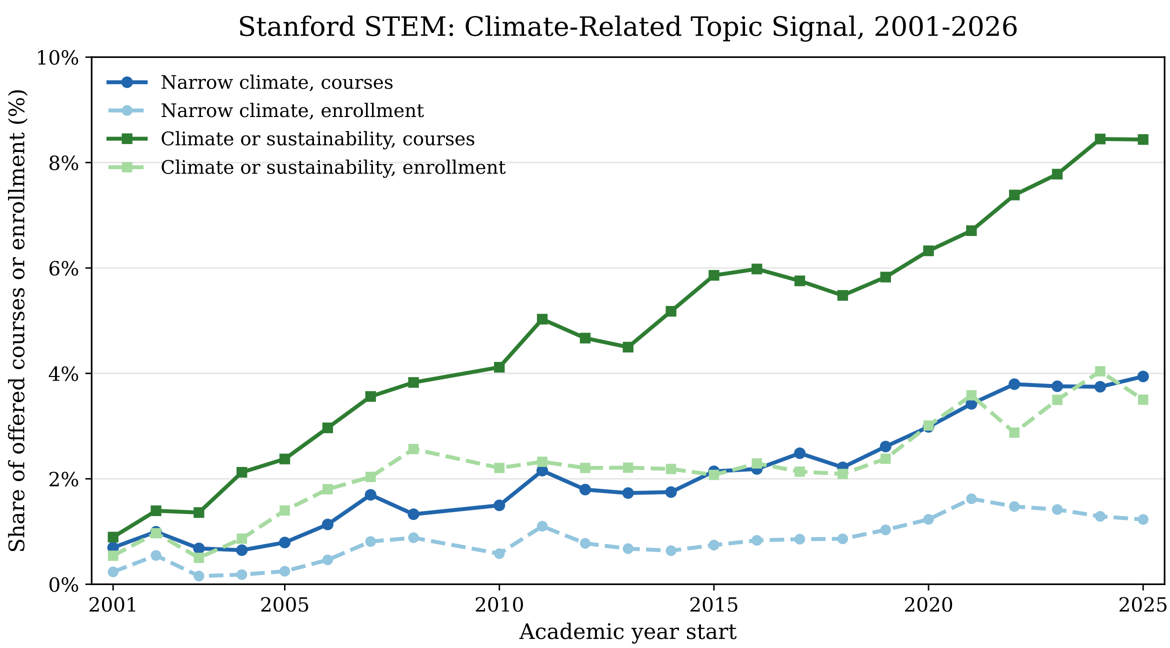

Figure 8: Stanford STEM climate-related topic signal with and without enrollment weights, 2001–2002 through 2025–2026.

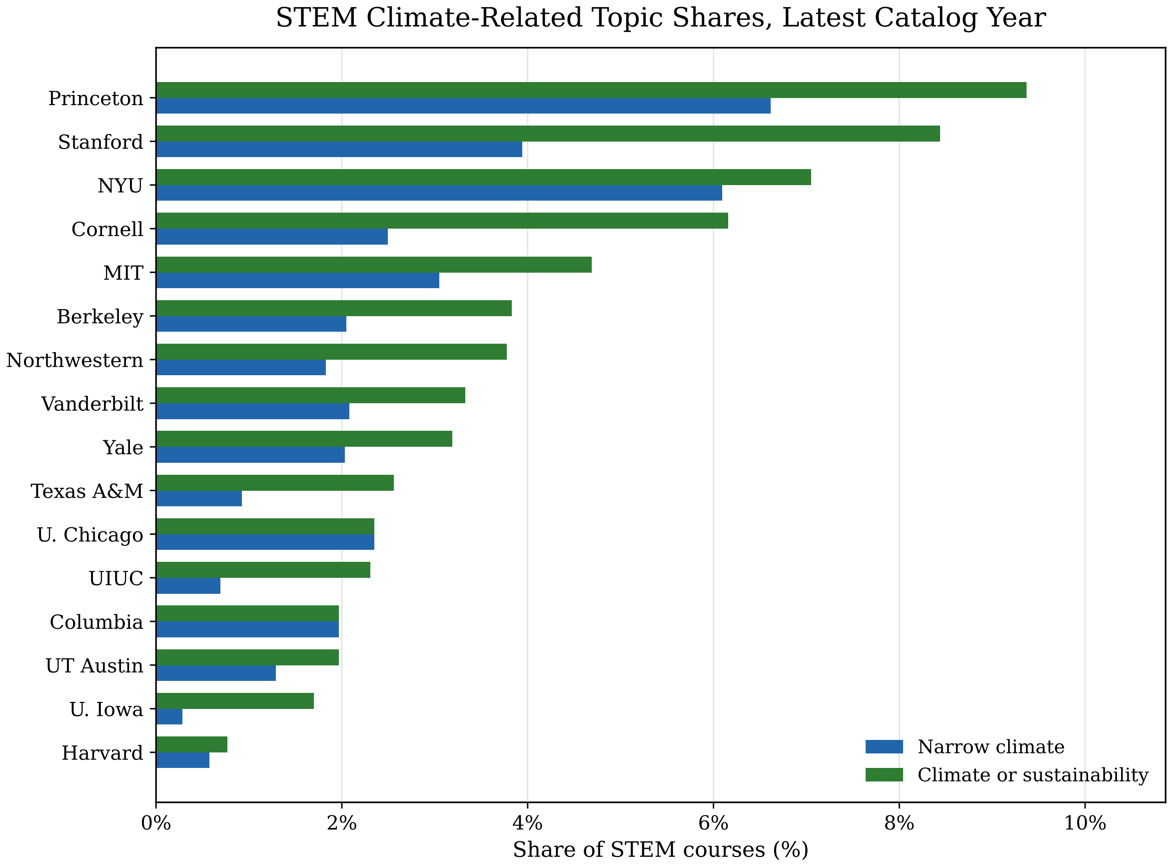

Figure 9: STEM climate-related topic shares by university, latest available 2024 or 2025 catalog observation.

Table 14: STEM climate-related topic shares by university, latest available 2024 or 2025 catalog observation.

University	Year	STEM courses	Narrow climate %	Climate/sustain. %
Princeton	2025	363	6.6	9.4
Stanford	2025	1,446	3.9	8.4
NYU	2025	312	6.1	7.1
Cornell	2025	2,810	2.5	6.2
MIT	2024	1,706	3.0	4.7
Berkeley	2025	2,586	2.0	3.8
Northwestern	2025	875	1.8	3.8
Vanderbilt	2025	721	2.1	3.3
Yale	2025	345	2.0	3.2
Texas A&M	2024	977	0.9	2.6
U. Chicago	2024	298	2.3	2.3
UIUC	2024	1,300	0.7	2.3
Columbia	2025	508	2.0	2.0
UT Austin	2025	1,476	1.3	2.0
U. Iowa	2025	1,060	0.3	1.7
Harvard	2025	522	0.6	0.8